Sikarwar, who joined the Congress and secured their seats in the bypolls.

With a pedigreed leader like Joshi quitting ahead of polls, the state BJP would seem to have failed to establish a dialogue within its own home. "The BJP would like us to believe those leaving the party have been marginalised and cannot damage its prospects. This may be true in some cases, but an exit from any party has a psychological impact on the voter. None of them has come across as greedy leaders," says senior journalist N.K. Singh.

Amid Joshi's exit, BJP leader

THE CIRCUMSTANCES THAT LED JOSHI TO JOIN THE CONGRESS ARE VALID FOR A NUMBER OF OTHER BJP LEADERS TOO

Kailash Vijayvargiya, who has been looking for a new role, also weighed in. "There are issues within the BJP that are being addressed. The Congress doesn't have it in itself to defeat the BJP in Madhya Pradesh. But yes, if we don't address the issues in the organisation, the BJP will defeat the BJP."

There are others who managed to bend the BJP to their will. In the April 2021 Damoh bypoll, Congress import Rahul Lodhi was fielded as the BJP candidate as per the 'understanding'. The Congress won hands down, due to the perceived role of Siddharth Malaiya, son of ex-minister Jayant Malaiya—ironically, the BJP man who lost to Lodhi in 2018 when he was fighting from the other side. In 2021, the BJP suspended Siddharth for fielding his own candidates in urban body polls. This April, the party took him back, implying a more pragmatic approach to prevent a vote split. Just as well. For, in the season of shifting allegiances, the freight of ideology tends to be light. ■



BIHAR

DON'T COUNT ON CASTE

By Amitabh Srivastava

Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's ambitious caste survey has hit a serious legal roadblock. On May 4, the Patna High Court put an interim stay on the state government's ongoing caste-wise enumeration of its population just 10 days before the May 15 deadline for all its field work to be wrapped up. The first round of the survey was carried out between January 7 and 21; the second had started on April 15 and nearly 80 per cent of the data is said to be in. Describing the survey as an attempt at a 'census'—the exclusive domain of Parliament—the court said the state does not have the legislative competence to conduct it. The 2011 census had collected caste data but its results were never revealed. The present state data—collected under 17 heads, one being 'caste'—has been similarly ordered to be preserved, secured and not be shared.

The high court stay may have far-reaching political implications, spilling way beyond Bihar. As the state government was inching